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Modes of persuasion

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Document Type: Article

Original Page: 40

Culture (OWC): [Tuareg \(MS25\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Northern Africa

Field Date: 1974-1991

Coverage Date: 1970-1990

Place Coverage: Niger

Section Title(S): Illness And Property Conflict

Tan daman is the title of the song. It refers to a specific drum pattern signifying a fleeting, difficult-to-recapture moment. The term itself denotes "in my soul" (from *iman*, soul). There is an appeal to contribute to and participate in the singing, in call and response patterns, and in ululating and applause. There is also an association between participation in performance and social solidarity beyond the immediate performance context of the curing ritual: the singer complains of being left alone like an orphan (*golama*). This image, of an abandoned orphan, is a frequent metaphor in exorcism song texts. The underlying idea is a correspondence between unified singing, social solidarity, and group therapy. The participation and approval sought are necessary for aesthetic excellence, which is, in turn, necessary for the cure. The image of orphanhood is an appeal for support during conflict in interpersonal relationships extending beyond the ritual context. These involve personal sentiments which are difficult to express directly in jural court settings or daily conversation. Such support is particularly important in view of the opposition to singing from the orthodox Moslem clergy, who are in many cases closely related to patients. "What is a song ...the word of the mouth" (*awal*, literally, "evil mouth," gossip, and criticism), addresses interpersonal disputes, in Ramatou's case with her cousin-neighbors. It also expresses a resentment toward authority figures (marabouts and noble men), who command official respect and yet do not always fulfill their obligations toward women. The issue emerging is how and why the words are effective and taken seriously at all.

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It is intrusive to place this song in a broader context, in terms of its numerous multivocal associations which work to shape public opinion, private shame, and transform prestigious status into an object of scorn. As observed,

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women have power to build or destroy men's reputations through song. More importantly, this symbolic force is backed up with the material power to eject men from the tent. Furthermore men, in particular those claiming noble descent, are most subject to strictures associated with *imojar*, or dignity. So the full force of both material residence and public verbal mockery converge in possession media imagery, when in fact the woman in trance is covered with, first, a tent-like blanket and in the later phase, with a tent-like face veil. In addition, as observed in the case of Hadia and Tina, women, too, fall subject to criticism when their individual acts and feelings threaten matrifocal domestic solidarity. The principal means of assertion in both cases operates like a mnemonic device in the performance, which in effect raises consciousness in reminding one of advantages in fulfilling obligations. Both men and women, more particularly nobles and non-nobles who aspire to traditional noble prerogatives and rewards, are sensitive to these values. Hence the power to shame in song, and gossip in tandem with song, as well as economic bases, lends more than a hollow ring.

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The present song laments the loving and losing of a certain Kane; there is reference to caravan travel south, and implied betrayal. It is the custom for returning caravanners to bring lavish gifts to their wives and sweethearts, displayed by the mother in her home and admired by close female friends and relatives. So this text uses a specific interpersonal conflict between female neighbors as a forum, thereby by diverting attention from it, to direct attention toward and address problems that are more pervasive in Tuareg society, and yet "closer to home": it attacks young suitors who pretend to be wealthy but really have nothing to offer their fiancées, but instead use pretense of wealth for purposes of seduction. It says, in effect, "Women, your problems are irritating, but nothing in comparison to the real problem: male outsiders in your tent." The term used here for young men, *imalayaden*, is pejorative; it connotes those who  41 deceive women and make false promises to marry, using misleading economic claims to do so. This alludes directly to Ramatou's household. Marabouts often work for the young man's family in bridewealth negotiations. So the verses encapsulate the contemporary conflict between economics and descent, and division between rich and poor nobility. A man loses his material wealth in the long run, and also his self-respect, if he doesn't please his mother-in-law through gifts. Yet official authority figures such as mothers-in-law and marabouts are also the butt of jokes and vengeful fantasies; they are put down indirectly in verbal art of folktales, possession songs, and riddles. The daughter is caught in the middle of the cross-fire between, first her suitor, the marabout, and her parents, and later, between her husband and her mother. She and her mother feed the husband, it is true, but the latter is nonetheless subjected to continual demands for millet and household implements from his mother-in-law, almost at whim. The newly-married daughter cannot please both her new husband and her mother.

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